meetings were intended to consolidate the ethnic groups' positions in relation to the nationwide ceasefire agreement.

The logistical arrangements of these conferences were a major concern to EAG members, who are spread all over the country, and some of whom do not have legal status. The peace technical team made it possible for the groups to meet by obtaining the government's endorsement and helping the EAGs with transportation of the ethnic leaders to the meeting destinations (Sai Wansai 2015). The team's facilitation of ethnic summits helped build trust in the government's commitment to the peace project and to bind the EAGs informally. On the other hand, the peace technical team left the 17(1) issue to be resolved in the future, specifically under the ceasefire agreement setting. Although the on-the-ground needs of the EAGs were fulfilled incrementally, they were still labelled as unlawful associations.

The peace technical team may have decided to defer the 17(1) issue because the underlying aspects of the problem are too big to be resolved within a short time frame or have some unwanted implications. During the negotiation meetings, the MPC suggested that it might address the 17(1) issue under the draft of a full NCA. According to a provision in Chapter 6 of the NCA document, all the EAGs signing the agreement would be removed from the list of unlawful associations (Nationwide Ceasefire Agreement 2015, p. 10). In order to gain legitimate status inside the country, it was imperative for the EAGs to get their organizations' names removed from the list, so the peace technical team could present this issue to the EAGs as one of the major driving forces to sign the NCA as soon as possible (Hlaing Kyaw Soe 2014). In fact, just a few days prior to the signing of the NCA on 15 October 2015, the government removed the groups signing from the list of unlawful associations. Therefore, interim agreements offered incentives to ethnic leaders to adhere to the negotiation process.

On the other hand, the peace technical team still managed to facilitate the EAGs' summits without intervening in formal aspects related to the 17(1) issue, leaving room for the Tatmadaw to exercise its power in ethnic politics. In practice, the Tatmadaw still leveraged the 17(1) provision in its relations with some EAGs fighting against it. It issued a warning to the NCCT concerning its Pang Sang conference invitation sent to three ethnic groups, namely the MNDAA, TNLA, and Arakan Army. It also warned media outlets over their association with the Kokang armed group,